

Chicago Tribune



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BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

State bets on virtual power plants

New concept could ease electric grid strain and costs

By Jerry Wu
Chicago Tribune

Central to Illinois' plan to expand energy resources and affordability is a program that could allow homes and businesses to become virtual power plants by contributing energy from their solar batteries to the electrical grid as early as in the next two years.

The Clean and Reliable Grid Affordability Act, passed during the state legislature's veto session in late October and awaiting the governor's signature, targets the procurement of 3 gigawatts of energy storage by 2030, enough to power millions of homes statewide.

One of the ways the energy bill aims to reach that goal is through the creation of a virtual power plant program that will pool energy from thousands of existing and newly built solar battery systems to the grid during peak hours of electricity use.

While Illinois energy consumption continues to climb — driven by the rapid growth of data centers and the state's electrification — VPP programs can offer a much more timely solution, industry experts say. Other programs in California, Massachusetts and Texas have already seen success addressing their growing energy demands and providing more savings to utility bills.

"A virtual power plant takes advantage of all the 21st-century energy technologies that consumers have right in their homes," said Nick Wallace, a senior associate lawyer from the Environmental Law and Policy Center.

VPPs tap into everyday home technologies, including solar panels and batteries, by drawing out excess stored energy with installed software to transmit to the grid during peak demands. Compared with

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Marimar Martinez outside a truck service shop on Friday, where she called 911 after she was shot five times in October by a Border Patrol agent in Brighton Park. Prosecutors claimed Martinez, as part of a convoy of protesters, rammed federal agents' vehicle and then tried to run over an agent, but felony charges were dropped after her attorney argued agents caused the crash and needlessly shot her. E. JASON WAMBSGANS/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Agents' claims against citizens mostly fall apart

Trump administration calls protesters 'agitators,' 'rioters' in rhetoric about resistance to Operation Midway Blitz, but most of its accusations have not held up in court

By Madeline Buckley,
Christy Gutowski
and Joe Mahr
Chicago Tribune

A week before Halloween, the Trump administration compared the alleged violence its federal immigration agents encountered on a particular day in the Chicago area to a plot ripped from a Hollywood movie about the FBI take-down of a brutal drug cartel.

The administration said U.S. citizens "stalked law enforcement, rammed vehicles, fled scenes, injured agents, and caused

multiple accidents." It called them "agitators" and "rioters."

Agents arrested six citizens, accusing them of impeding law enforcement and — in one case — alleging that a woman vowed to put out a hit on U.S. Customs and Border Protection Cmdr. Gregory Bovino.

"And if you lay a hand on a law enforcement officer," a news release warned, "you will be prosecuted to the fullest extent of the law."

But, two months later, the allegations in that 24 hours have not withstood the harsh light of the

federal court system. Just one of the six people has faced any federal charge. And that's a misdemeanor ticket that agents themselves issued. It has yet to go in front of a judge.

The day is emblematic of what the Tribune found to be a broader pattern of disconnect between the U.S. Department of Homeland Security's rhetoric of the dangers to agents during Operation Midway Blitz versus the reality borne out in the federal courts.

As federal agents swarmed the area in the aggressive immigration enforcement program,

they also swept up more than 100 people, most of whom were detained during public protests, traffic altercations or on residential streets.

A Tribune analysis found that, time and again, Trump's DHS claimed horrific abuses at the hands of protesters. Yet time and again, their allegations of abuse did not withstand the scrutiny of judicial review.

Of the 106 who could be identified as having been caught in the federal dragnet, just nine resulted

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BRIAN CASSELLA/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Frigid start to the workweek

People cross Wacker Drive in freezing, windy weather while a light snow falls on Monday in downtown Chicago. More snow is forecast for this afternoon. See the complete Chicagoland forecast on Page 12.

Tuesday	Wednesday	Thursday	Friday
High 25 Low 24	High 31 Low 7	High 21 Low 16	High 27 Low 15

INSIDE

City makes plea before NYE

Chicago's mayor and police chief urged parents to keep vigilant over their teens' whereabouts ahead of the downtown celebration. **Chicagoland, Page 3**

Inside Bears' loss to 49ers

The 49ers did what those other teams couldn't do: They prevented Caleb Williams from pulling off a magical throw on the final play. **Chicago Sports**

Ukraine gives details on US security pledge

Zelenskyy prefers 50 years over offer of 15 in peace plan

By Illia Novikov
Associated Press



Ukraine's President Volodymyr Zelenskyy speaks during a joint news conference with President Donald Trump on Sunday in Palm Beach, Fla. ALEX BRANDON/AP

KYIV, Ukraine — The United States is offering Ukraine security guarantees for a period of 15 years as part of a proposed peace plan, Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy said Monday, though he said he would prefer an American commitment of up to 50 years to deter Russia from further attempts to seize its neighbor's land by force.

President Donald Trump hosted Zelenskyy at his Florida resort on Sunday and insisted that Ukraine and Russia are "closer than ever before" to a peace settlement.

Negotiators are still searching for a breakthrough on key issues, however, including whose forces withdraw from where in Ukraine and the fate of Ukraine's Russian-occupied Zaporizhzhia nuclear power plant, one of the 10 biggest in the world. Trump noted that the monthslong U.S.-led negotiations could still collapse.

"Without security guarantees, realistically, this war will

not end," Zelenskyy told reporters in voice messages responding to questions sent via a WhatsApp chat.

Ukraine has been fighting Russia since 2014, when it illegally annexed Crimea and Moscow-backed separatists took up arms in the Donbas, a vital industrial region in eastern Ukraine.

Details of the security guarantees have not become public, but Zelenskyy said Monday they include how a peace deal would be monitored as well as the "presence" of partners. He didn't elaborate, but Russia has said it won't accept the deployment in Ukraine of troops from

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